

TASK 2 — INVITATION JOURNEY

Priority invitee: Dhiraj Kumar Vashista

Role: Whole Time Director & CFO, HGS (India) Limited

My approach

For Dhiraj, I would not start by directly asking him to join Friends of Finance. He has a senior finance profile, so a generic community invitation is unlikely to stand out.

Instead, I would first connect with him based on his experience in finance leadership, FP&A and transformation. If he responds, I would then explain what Friends of Finance is and why I thought it could be relevant to him.

The overall approach would be:

Connect → Start a conversation → Introduce FoF → Show relevant value → Give him space

1. LinkedIn connection

Message I would send:

Hi Dhiraj, I came across your profile while looking at finance leaders with experience in FP&A and finance transformation. I'm currently helping with Friends of Finance, a community for finance professionals to share practical experiences. Your background caught my attention, so I thought I'd connect.

I wouldn't mention too much about the community in the connection request. The main aim here is simply to make the connection feel relevant and personal.

2. After he accepts

I would wait for the connection to be accepted and then send something like:

Thanks for connecting, Dhiraj.

The reason I reached out is that I'm working with Friends of Finance, which is a community for finance and accounting professionals.

The idea is pretty simple — people share things they've actually dealt with at work, whether that's finance processes, transformation, systems, career decisions or a problem they're trying to solve.

Given your experience in finance leadership and FP&A, I thought some of those conversations might be relevant to you.

Happy to share more about it if you'd like to take a look.

This gives him context without immediately pushing an invitation.

3. Email invitation

If he shows some interest, I would send a proper invitation by email.

Subject: Invitation to Friends of Finance

Hi Dhiraj,

Good connecting with you on LinkedIn.

I wanted to share a little more about Friends of Finance.

It's a community for finance and accounting professionals where people can discuss the kind of things they actually deal with at work — finance processes, transformation, tools, career decisions and problems where getting another finance professional's perspective can help.

I thought of you particularly because of your experience across finance leadership, FP&A and transformation.

I also think your experience could be useful to other members who are working through similar challenges.

If it sounds interesting, I'd be happy to share the community with you. You can have a look and decide whether it's something you'd find useful.

Regards,
Yukesh

I would keep the email fairly short. A senior finance professional probably doesn't need a long explanation of what a community is.

4. Follow-up with something useful

I wouldn't send:

"Hi Dhiraj, just following up on my previous message."

There isn't much value in that.

Instead, I would give him a specific reason why I thought of him.

Message:

Hi Dhiraj,

One thing I thought might be particularly relevant to your background is the Finance Workflows side of Friends of Finance.

It's focused on how finance teams actually work through processes and problems, rather than just discussing finance concepts.

There is also a Tools & Systems section around things like ERP, automation, reporting and implementation.

Given your experience with finance transformation, I thought those discussions might be worth a look.

No pressure either way — just wanted to give you a better idea of why I thought the community could be relevant.

The point here is that I'm adding context, rather than asking him again whether he joined.

The Friends of Finance guide specifically describes Finance Workflows around real finance processes and Tools & Systems around ERP, software, dashboards, automation and implementation.

5. Closing the conversation

If there is still no response, I would stop.

Final message:

Hi Dhiraj,

I'll leave it here for now regarding Friends of Finance. I know you probably have a busy schedule, and I don't want to keep sending follow-ups.

If the community becomes relevant to you sometime in the future, happy to reconnect.

Thanks for your time.

I think this is better than sending several more reminders. Even if he doesn't join, the interaction should still end positively.

Handling Different Responses

A. "I don't want to join another promotional group."

I wouldn't try to convince him immediately.

I'd reply:

Totally understand. I wouldn't want another promotional group either.

The reason I reached out is that Friends of Finance is actually focused more on peer discussions — people sharing real finance experiences, asking questions and learning from other finance professionals.

But if it's not something you're looking for right now, no problem at all. I just wanted to clarify what the community is about.

This acknowledges his concern without arguing with him.

The FoF guide describes the community around real finance experiences, peer learning and practical discussions rather than promotional content.

B. "Is this a Volopay sales community?"

I would be careful here because I wouldn't want to make a claim that isn't supported by the assignment materials.

I'd say:

That's a fair question.

From the information I have, Friends of Finance is presented as a professional community for finance and accounting professionals, with discussions around finance workflows, tools, career topics and real work experiences.

I don't want to give you the wrong information about the exact relationship between Volopay and Friends of Finance, because that isn't clearly explained in the material I have.

What I can tell you is that the community itself is positioned around peer learning and professional discussions rather than simply promoting products.

This is better than pretending to know something that I don't.

C. If there is no response

What would I do?

I would stop after the five touches.

I wouldn't keep sending messages every few days.

There are plenty of possible reasons for no response:

- He is busy.
- The timing isn't right.

- He isn't interested.
- He doesn't regularly check LinkedIn.
- The community isn't relevant to him at the moment.

So I wouldn't treat silence as a reason to increase the number of messages.

Would I ever approach him again?

Yes, but only if there is a genuine new reason.

For example, if he later posts about:

- Finance transformation
- FP&A
- Finance systems
- Automation
- A finance problem where peer input would be useful

then I could potentially reconnect with something genuinely relevant.

I wouldn't simply wait two weeks and send:

"Hi Dhiraj, just following up again."

Why I chose this approach

I would rather have five useful interactions than five sales messages.

The first message is about him.

The second explains why I contacted him.

The third gives him the actual invitation.

The fourth gives him a specific reason to care.

The fifth respects his decision.

That seems more appropriate for Friends of Finance because the community itself is supposed to encourage real conversations between finance professionals, rather than making every interaction feel like a promotion.